

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN LITHUANIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Lithuania's distinctive lever — rousing the countryside, moving the parliament, and changing the ground under a project until it no longer pays — and it names the tools you'll meet (the EIA and permit, the local and rural community, legislative and regulatory pressure, the water-and-farmland case, the courts) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Around 2012 and 2013, the government invited the American company **Chevron** to explore for **shale gas** under western Lithuania — the forested, farmed country of the Žemaitija region near the Baltic — and named it the winner of the tender. But the farmers and landowners who lived on that land did not want their water and their fields **fracked**. They protested in the capital, drums beating and signs telling Chevron to go home; environmental groups joined them; and the parliament, feeling the pressure, **tightened the environmental rules** and floated a **heavy tax on shale gas**. In October 2013, Chevron **withdrew**, citing the changed regulatory landscape and the public resistance. The tender was cancelled, and the fracking did not come. A small nation, courted by a global oil giant and told the project was in its national interest, had sent the giant away.

The farmers of Žemaitija and the Lithuanian public sent Chevron away — not by objection alone, but by making the country an unwelcome, unrewarding place for the project — and the tools they used are available to communities across Lithuania. A project needs an **EIA and permit**, open to objection. The **rural communities on the land** are a powerful, sympathetic force. **Legislative and regulatory pressure**, through a responsive parliament, can change the ground under a project — as the tightened rules and the floated shale-gas tax changed Chevron's calculation. The **water-and-farmland case** unites the countryside, and protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And the **courts**, with Aarhus rights, are open. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly — and this is a win more tangled than most. Chevron's withdrawal was driven **partly by regulation, taxes, and its own business calculations**, not by protest alone. The project was pitched as a way to **reduce Lithuania's total dependence on Russian gas**, so the environmental win sat in real tension with an **energy-security** argument, and some called the pullout a gift to the eastern gas monopoly — a reminder that a "win" can carry complicated implications a community must weigh honestly. And the threat **recurred**: the government later tried to revive shale gas, so the win was a **reprieve to be defended**, not a permanent ban. A campaign facing a national-interest pitch must take the competing good seriously and answer it — insisting the nation's water and farmland can be protected *and* its independence pursued by better means.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals and calculations, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Lithuanian project needs its **EIA and permit**; it can be objected to and taken to the **courts**; and — the distinctive move — the **parliament and regulator can change the rules and taxes** until the venture no longer pays. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and changing the ground under the project is the one that sent Chevron away. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If you can rouse the countryside and move the parliament, you can change the ground under the project** — making it unrewarding, as Lithuania did to Chevron.
- **If the harm is to water and farmland, that case unites the rural public** — the wells and fields people live on.
- **If it's pitched as the national interest, take the competing good seriously and answer it** — protect the land *and* address the real concern, or lose the wider public.
- **If the threat can recur, treat the win as a reprieve to be defended, not a permanent ban** — and stay organised.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **rouse the countryside, move the parliament, change the ground under the project**, and **answer the national-interest pitch honestly**, because a win that ignores the real competing good can be undone. That's how Chevron was sent away.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

A project needs an **EIA and permit** from the environment authority, and a **tender or licence** from the government. But the **parliament** sets the rules and taxes that govern whether a project pays, and a responsive parliament can **change that ground**. The **courts**, with Aarhus rights, review decisions. And the **rural communities and the public** carry unusual weight when their water and farmland are at stake. Know which decision — permit, or the rules and taxes around it — you can reach, and aim there.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The EIA and permit. The project is assessed and permitted. *Your opening:* object, put the water-and-farmland case on the record, and attack the assessment's flaws.

The legislative and regulatory ground. *Your opening — the distinctive one:* press the parliament and regulator to **tighten the rules and raise the taxes** until the venture no longer pays.

The public and the countryside. *Your opening:* rouse the rural communities and the national public with the water-and-farmland case.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — the foreign company, and the tender that named it. **What makes it pay — and what would make it not** — because the rules and taxes are the ground you can change. **How it's pitched** — because if it's sold as the national interest, you must answer the competing good.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment authority** runs the EIA and permit. The **parliament** sets the rules and taxes — and can change them. The **courts** review decisions. And Lithuania's **rural communities, farmers, environmental groups, and a free press** are the forces that reach furthest — the coalition that

sent Chevron away.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether you can rouse the countryside and move the parliament, whether the water-and-farmland case unites the public, and whether you answer the national-interest pitch.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the EIA	15–35%	during assessment	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Rouse the rural communities + public	30–55%	months	low	Pressure; a national cause
Water-and-farmland campaign	30–55%	months–yr	low	The countryside united
Move the parliament (rules and taxes)	35–60%	months–yr	low	The ground changed; the venture unpaying
Court challenge (permit)	25–50%	months–2 yr	mod	Permit quashed; process ordered
Answer the national-interest pitch	(enabling)	throughout	low	The wider public kept onside
Everything together (countryside roused, parliament moved)	40–65%	1–2 yr	mod	Backer withdraws; tender cancelled
Everything together (strong national-interest pitch)	20–45%	1–2 yr	mod	Delayed; conditioned; recurring

The lever that moves the needle most is **moving the parliament to change the rules and taxes** — making the venture unrewarding — backed by a roused countryside and the water-and-farmland case. Chevron shows the ceiling (a global giant sent away) and the honest floor (driven partly by business calculation, in tension with energy security, and recurring). So aim for a backer withdrawn, a tender cancelled, delay, and a reprieve to defend — and answer the competing good.

On cost: objecting, organising, and campaigning are cheap; moving the parliament costs pressure, not money; the strength is a roused countryside and a responsive parliament. The great requirement is honesty about the competing good — because a campaign that ignores a real national-interest concern loses the wider public it needs.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this water threat, this tax, this unanswered national-interest pitch — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the foreign company, and the tender that named it.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Map it over **wells, water, farmland, and forest**. The threat to **water and farmland — the wells and fields people live on — is your sharpest, most unifying lever**, as it roused Žemaitija.

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is the EIA in objection? Is the tender or permit granted? Is there a legislative window (a tax, a rule change)? These openings are time-bound.

4. What makes it pay — and what would make it not? Identify the rules and taxes you could press the parliament to change, to make the venture unrewarding.

5. How is it pitched — and what's the competing good? If it's sold as energy security or the national interest, name the real concern, so you can answer it and keep the wider public.

What this looks like in real life. A foreign energy giant wins a tender to frack the countryside, pitched as reducing dependence on a hostile neighbour's gas. The five questions yield: a company and its tender; a water-and-farmland threat (the unifying lever); an EIA or permit in process; rules and taxes to change; and a national-interest pitch to answer. That's the Chevron pattern — rouse the countryside, move the parliament, change the ground, and answer the competing good.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the project rests on — the EIA, the permit, the tender, the company's plans, the rules and taxes that govern it. Then read the EIA for flaws — understated risk to water and farmland, ignored alternatives.

Layer two: the water-and-farmland case. Marshal the evidence on the threat to **wells, water, and farmland** — the science on fracking's risks to groundwater and land — and gather the testimony of the farmers and villagers above the shale. This is the case that unites the countryside.

Layer three: the ground you can change. Document the **rules and taxes** that make the venture pay, and the changes — tighter environmental rules, a shale-gas tax — that would make it not. And prepare an honest answer to the **national-interest pitch**: how the land can be protected *and* the real concern addressed by better means. This turns your documentation into a strategy to change the company's calculation.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The EIA, the permit, the tender, the company's plans, the rules and taxes** — from the environment authority and the government.
- **The water-and-farmland science** — on fracking's risks to groundwater and land.
- **The legislative levers** — the rules and taxes the parliament could change.
- **The answer to the national-interest pitch** — how to protect the land and address the real concern.
- **Named testimony** — of the farmers and villagers above the shale.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a roused countryside joined to a responsive parliament gives you power — the Chevron model. Build in four moves.

Start with the rural communities. The farmers and villagers above the shale — whose wells and fields are at stake — are the campaign's heart and its most sympathetic voice. Organise them first.

Unite the countryside on water and farmland. The threat to water and farmland is what unites a rural nation and draws the cities' sympathy. Lead with it — the wells, the fields, the land people live on.

Carry the pressure to the parliament. The distinctive move: translate the public pressure into **legislative and regulatory change** — tighter rules, a shale-gas tax — through a responsive parliament, changing the ground under the project.

Answer the national-interest pitch — and build to last. Take the energy-security concern seriously and answer it, or lose the wider public. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the toll — and the vigilance to defend the reprieve, because the threat can recur.

STEP 4: LEGAL, LEGISLATIVE & REGULATORY LEVERS

Lithuania's sharpest lever is changing the ground under the project, backed by the courts and the countryside.

Move the Parliament — Change the Ground

The Chevron move: translate public and rural pressure into **legislative and regulatory change** — **tighter environmental rules and a heavy tax** — that makes the venture **unrewarding**. A company that cannot be stopped by objection alone can be made to leave when the rules and taxes and the friction of a hostile public change its cold calculation of cost and reward. This is Lithuania's most powerful and distinctive lever.

The EIA and the Courts

Object in the **EIA**, and challenge a defective **permit** in the **courts**, with **Aarhus** rights to information and participation. These build the record, buy time, and add to the friction.

Answer the National-Interest Pitch

Where the project is pitched as the national interest — reducing dependence on a hostile neighbour's gas — **take the competing good seriously and answer it**: insist the water and farmland can be protected *and* independence pursued by better means (efficiency, other supplies, renewables). A campaign that denounces the project without answering the real concern cedes the moral high ground and loses the wider public.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: changing the ground and moving the parliament are powerful, but the withdrawal may owe as much to business calculation as to protest, the win can sit in tension with a real competing good, and the threat can recur. So use the strong tools — the legislative and regulatory pressure, the roused countryside, the EIA and courts — answer the competing good, defend the reprieve, and count a backer withdrawn, a tender cancelled, delay, and a reprieve held as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Water becomes the countryside's cause. Not "we oppose fracking" but *"this would frack the wells and fields we live on — our water and our farmland."*

Pressure becomes a tax and a rule. *"We ask the parliament to tighten the rules and tax the venture, until it no longer pays,"* as Lithuania did.

The national-interest pitch becomes an answered concern. *"We share the goal of independence from a hostile gas monopoly — and we can achieve it without fracking our water; here is how."*

A defective permit becomes a challenge. *"The EIA understated the risk to our groundwater — the permit is unsound."*

Match it to the venue: the water case to the countryside and the public; the rules and taxes to the parliament; the answered concern to the wider public; the defective permit to the courts.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Lithuania, the countryside's cause and the national debate are the levers — a water-and-farmland fight, honestly answering the energy-security concern, can move the public and the parliament. A free press makes the media front central.

Lead with water and farmland, not procedure. Not "the EIA was deficient" but "the wells and fields we live on, to be fracked by a foreign giant." Use your strongest material: the water science, the farmers' voices, dated photographs, and any legislative or court progress banked.

Work several audiences at once — and answer the pitch. Rural and national press rouse the countryside and the public; the honest answer to the energy-security concern keeps the wider public onside; the parliament feels both. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything, especially on the science and the energy-security question. And engage the competing good honestly, rather than pretending it away, or you lose the public.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the authority).

Subject: Request for the EIA and tender — [project].

"We, residents of [place], request the EIA, the permit, and the tender for [project] in [region]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the EIA.

Subject: Objection — [project].

"We, residents of [place], object to [project]: [it threatens our wells, water, and farmland; the EIA understates the risk]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach the water evidence.]"

8C — To the parliament (rules and taxes).

Subject: Tighten the rules and tax [project].

"We, residents of [region], ask the parliament to tighten the environmental rules and impose a tax on [project], to protect our water and farmland — as was done with shale gas in 2013. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Answering the national-interest pitch (public / officials).

Subject: Independence without fracking our water.

"We share the goal of energy independence from [the gas monopoly]. But [project] would frack the water and farmland we live on — and we can pursue independence by better means: [efficiency / other supplies / renewables]. [Attach the alternative.]"

8E — To a lawyer (court challenge).

Subject: Possible challenge — [project] permit.

"Our community faces [project] threatening our water on [a defective permit]. We've gathered [the EIA, the water science]. We ask your advice on challenging it and enforcing our Aarhus rights. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the company.

Subject: Regulatory, tax, and public risk in [project].

"We are the community affected by [project] at [location]. It faces a hostile public, tightening rules, and a possible tax, and threatens our water and farmland. As with Chevron in 2013, this makes the venture unrewarding. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Community] moves to protect its water and farmland from [project].

"The people of [region] live by [these wells and fields]. Now [project] threatens to frack them. We can provide the water science, the farmers' voices, and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rousing the countryside.

Subject: Our water and our land — here's how we protect them.

"[Project] threatens the wells and fields we live on. In 2013, a roused countryside and a responsive parliament sent Chevron away — by tightening the rules and taxing the venture until it no longer paid. If we rouse the countryside and move the parliament, we can too. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Organise the rural communities on the water-and-farmland case (8H).** That's your heart and your unifying cause.

2. **Object in the EIA (8B), and request the documents (8A).**
3. **Carry the pressure to the parliament for tighter rules and a tax (8C) — change the ground.**
4. **Answer the national-interest pitch honestly (8D), to keep the wider public.**
5. **Get a lawyer for a defective permit (8E).**
6. **Go public (8G), signal the risk to the company (8F) — and defend the reprieve, because it can recur.**

Even lean, those six rouse the countryside, move the parliament, and change the ground — the Chevron template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Lithuania's tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When it's pitched as the national interest. Don't dismiss it: take the competing good — energy security — seriously and answer it, or lose the wider public. Protect the land *and* address the real concern.

When the win owes to business calculation. Chevron left partly for its own reasons. Don't overclaim, and keep changing the ground so the venture stays unrewarding.

When the threat recurs. The government later tried to revive shale gas. Treat the win as a reprieve, stay organised, and be ready to fight again.

When the parliament is unresponsive. Build the rural and public pressure until it moves, and use the EIA and courts meanwhile.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Lithuania has real concerns about the closeness of energy interests to tenders and decisions, so this matters.

How to spot it. Tenders and permits against the evidence; EIAs written for the proponent; deals on opaque terms; benefits to the connected while the countryside bears the risk.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **National Audit Office** examines public money. The **Special Investigation Service** handles graft. The **courts** can quash a tainted permit. And Lithuania's **press and civil society** have exposed captured decisions.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the bent process, who benefits, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit and anti-corruption bodies, the courts, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the legislative and public pressure.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents and the water science build your case; the water-and-farmland cause rouses the countryside; the legislative pressure changes the ground; the courts check the permit; the honest answer keeps the public; the press builds the movement. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and defend the reprieve.

Early on (weeks 1–8): organise the rural communities on the water case; object in the EIA; request the records; identify the rules and taxes to change; prepare the answer to the national-interest pitch.

In the thick of it (months–year): rouse the countryside and the public; carry the pressure to the parliament; challenge a defective permit; open the media front.

The long haul (year+): hold the legislative and public pressure until the venture no longer pays; answer the competing good throughout; defend the reprieve against revival; hold the line for a backer withdrawn, a tender cancelled, delay, and a reprieve held.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Lithuania can be done — a roused countryside and a responsive parliament sent a global oil giant away, protecting the nation's water and farmland from fracking. Hold both truths. Lithuania's distinctive power is real: a determined public and the rural communities on the land, joined to legislative and regulatory pressure, can make a country an unwelcome, unrewarding place for a destructive project — even one pitched as the national interest — and change its backers' cold calculation of cost and reward. And the constraints are real, and this win is tangled: the withdrawal owed partly to business calculation, the environmental win sat in tension with a genuine energy-security good, and the threat recurred.

Here's the discipline that wins. Organise the rural communities on the water-and-farmland case — the wells and fields people live on — and rouse the wider public with it. Then do the distinctive thing: carry that pressure to the parliament and change the ground under the project, tightening the rules and taxing the venture until it no longer pays. Object in the EIA and challenge a defective permit in the courts. And crucially, where the project is pitched as the national interest, take that competing good seriously and answer it — protect the land *and* pursue independence by better means — or lose the wider public you need. Treat the win as a reprieve to be defended, because the threat can recur. Count a backer withdrawn, a tender cancelled, delay, and a reprieve held as wins. That's what Lithuania did — rouse the countryside, move the parliament, change the ground, and answer the competing good together. So can you.